it comes to plastic contamination. It is almost impossible to collect and then absolutely impossible to process. The only thing that can be done with it is to incinerate it at cement plants, which almost never happens. How do we know? Because the rare comprehensive study of the kind of plastic found at landfills invariably throws this up. Remember that when you reach for the few pieces of spiced potato inside that colourful yellow piece of plastic.



GETTY IMAGES

What must be done? Two simple steps, covering all casually used, non-specialised forms of plastic—which is nearly half of what's produced. First, even the last carry bag and earbud and chips packet must be collected. Two, this waste plastic material, once collected, must be recycled or incinerated—under no circumstances must it be allowed to make its way into landfills or waterbodies. The incineration must obviously be done in an environment-friendly way, not end up creating more pollution or health hazards for workers. Here, we have the additional burden brought on by Covid-19, which has—unfortunately, if unavoidably—meant an explosion of plastic in our midst, even more normalised in the form of protection gear, from gloves to body suits.

Collection itself is a notoriously difficult task. Take carry bags, for instance. The ban on them is not a new thing—some 25 states and Union territories already have a complete ban on them. But we know how it works out in practice. The thickness, especially, is an area of concern: governments and regulators take the easy way out by saying it's difficult to judge and regulate. Enforcing this in right earnest will be our biggest challenge—the make-or-break element in this battle.

The other challenge is the fixing of responsibility. The government makes well-intentioned noises—witness Prime Minister Narendra Modi's powerful call during I-Day 2019, asking Indians to give up the "habit of plastic". Now, all packaging material is supposed to be part of 'extended producer responsibility', where manufacturing (or consuming) companies are required to collect the amount of waste they generate and despatch it for reprocessing. There are annual targets. Seems to work like clockwork...in theory. In reality, the quantum of plastic made/consumed by industry is measured only by them. Nothing is available in the public domain for us to assess the accuracy of what they declare. The EPR system is, thus, a hollow one—even if you discount the alarming fact that they have a generous window of two years to recycle the waste they produce today.

What plays in the meantime? Half-solutions that merely serve to hide the truth. On a visit to an authorised agency, contracted by companies to collect waste on their behalf to meet their EPR targets, I saw waste brought by municipal trucks being put on conveyor belts and getting sorted. Reusable stuff—aluminium et al—was going back to the market. In the end, they were saddled with mountains of cleanly sorted plastic that had nowhere to go: transporting to cement incinerators was too costly for them. Multi-layered packaging and pouches formed the bulk of this. The agency was running out of space.

IF WE WANT TO BAN SINGLE-USE PLASTIC OF ALL SORTS, THE LIST MUST INCLUDE THE MULTI-LAYERED PACKAGING WE GET OUR CHIPS, GUTKHA AND SHAMPOO IN

Further down the value chain for big business—and most middle class—are the millions in the informal sector who actually manage to find options for plastic reuse. Our real waste warriors, who at least defer the burden on the planet. Beyond that, you have the recycling "factories"—a Dickensian world where more poor people work in appalling conditions to atone for our sins. Inside one in Bawana, an industrial locality in Delhi, plastic segregated into types is first cleaned in vats, boiled, heated and made to run through coils until it becomes like wire. This is then shredded into plastic granules that take on new forms before reaching you again.

Ensuring that we insist on recycled